

what open source technology offers them. Developers have a whole range of technology to learn and work on, as every company using open source is doing something different. While Agriya offers developers a chance to work on PHP and Web development using open source tools, GlobalLogic develops open source derived tools, processes and offers its consulting services to help companies develop products using the open source stack, quickly and cost-effectively. e-con Systems gives its developers a chance to play with open embedded systems like device driver development, rapid product development kits, computers on modules running Linux, Linux application development etc. Aspire Systems, on the other hand, allows developers to try their hand at Web 2.0 solutions, performance optimisation and mobile application development. So from embedded technology and consumer electronics to Web 2.0 technologies, the opportunities for open source developers are endless and growing.

Exciting tests

Open source also offers developers an environment that keeps the adrenaline pumping. "Open source throws challenges in plenty to developers. When our developers use these tools in their premature stages, they face problems like finding the right documentation, integration issues, etc. The high frequency of updates also is a tough battle to be won. Today the team might be using version 1.0 of an open source tool for a project and the next month you might have version 1.5 out. Further, being indirect users of multiple open source technologies, they battle issues of version mismatch, clashes, etc," says Gupta. Exciting challenges also exist in the open embedded

Company name	Number of FOSS professionals	Requirement in the future
Agriya	100	75
Aspire Systems	140	60-80
GlobalLogic	1800 (globally)	600 (globally), 200 (India)
Sonata Software*	150	—
e-con Systems	20	4
NextBit Computing*	20	—

The * marked companies were unable to share their requirement figures.

space. "One major problem with the use of open source in embedded devices is stability. There is a lack of testing as no one takes ownership in the community. As a result, very few applications are well tested and work perfectly. Most aren't stable. We have to unearth the problems and resolve existing problems to make it work perfectly. Thus, the challenges are plenty and exciting for our developers," says Veerabahu.

The road to excellence

Apart from a challenging work environment, open source offers a chance for developers to go deeper into R&D and achieve excellence. A large number of companies using open source for product/project development are working on building centres of excellence (CoE). For instance, Aspire Systems is building a centre of excellence (CoE), with a 20-member team working on new adaptations in projects, setting and achieving new milestones for research in the area of Web 2.0 and mobile solutions, using open source. The CoE has so far offered consultancy to six projects in the area of Web 2.0 technologies.

Similarly, Sonata Software has set up an open source CoE. Sonata's open source CoE has built re-usable components that can be integrated with third-party tools.

